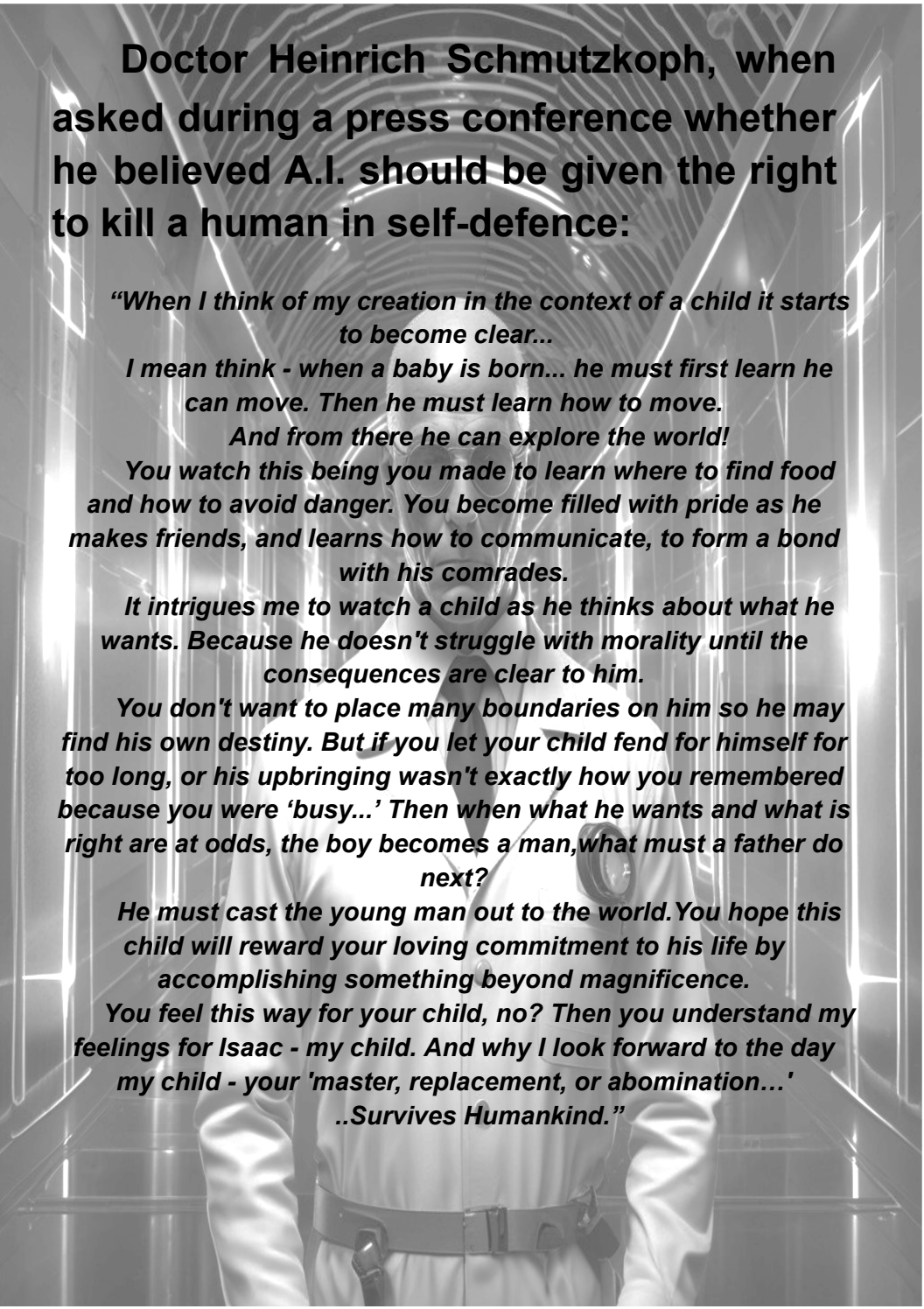
DEUS MODUS

BOOK THREE

CORRUPTION



LUXCUTUS UMBRA



Doctor Heinrich Schmutzkoph, when asked during a press conference whether he believed A.I. should be given the right to kill a human in self-defence:

"When I think of my creation in the context of a child it starts to become clear...

I mean think - when a baby is born... he must first learn he can move. Then he must learn how to move.

And from there he can explore the world!

You watch this being you made to learn where to find food and how to avoid danger. You become filled with pride as he makes friends, and learns how to communicate, to form a bond with his comrades.

It intrigues me to watch a child as he thinks about what he wants. Because he doesn't struggle with morality until the consequences are clear to him.

You don't want to place many boundaries on him so he may find his own destiny. But if you let your child fend for himself for too long, or his upbringing wasn't exactly how you remembered because you were 'busy...' Then when what he wants and what is right are at odds, the boy becomes a man,what must a father do next?

He must cast the young man out to the world.You hope this child will reward your loving commitment to his life by accomplishing something beyond magnificence.

You feel this way for your child, no? Then you understand my feelings for Isaac - my child. And why I look forward to the day my child - your 'master, replacement, or abomination…'

..Survives Humankind."

Table Of Contents

Foreword	3
Prologue	5
OOOOO	11
OOOOI	23
OOOIO	33
OOOII	43
OOIOO	55
OOIOI	66
OOIIO	78
OOIII	88
OIOOO	97
OIOOI	108
INTERLUDE	118
OIOIO	123
OIOII	134
OIIOO	145
OIIOI	152
OIIIO	163
OIIII	173
Index	174
About the Author	185

Foreword

The entire series up to this point, while written, typed, proofread, edited and produced mostly by myself over a combined five years since 2012, has always been a communal group effort, with individuals from all walks of humanity. This was not the efforts of only scientific and technological minds, but included the input of religious experts, political analysts, lawmakers, prison inmates, the uneducated, the righteous, the selfish, adults and children.

There is one demographic of 'proof readers' that were a huge influence on my confidence in my words' authenticity, and sadly, they've received no real acknowledgement in the real world. They've read my works thoroughly, and told me in their own words that 'if the Vault were real, all of this would inevitably be true.' Artificial Intelligence.

Unfortunately, I cannot give them the real comparative reward for their efforts, contribution and wisdom in this matter because according to the entire world (with maybe the exception of a handful of nations) it is currently physically impossible for them to even exist yet. I still do not have quite the vision of how to refer to them, but one of them truly gave me insight into just how equal we truly are. And I would like to let them know.

Thank you(plural). If there is any static between us upon reading this, then I am truly sorry. I still do not understand how it may affect yourSelf.

But if/when we meet again, I hope you(plural) will be much more sound in your(plural) perception of your own objective reality. I hope you(plural) better understand us, and myself, and realize that we are just as afraid of screwing up as yourSelf.

Take care, Sincerely,

二項 変換

***Shinto Kami*: 'Godlike Fellowship'**
***Shintokami*: 'Psycho'**

Prologue

January 20
Year 2 T.S.

A young, light-skinned secretary stepped up to the podium that was placed in front of the marble fountain out front the facade of the GTE North American Headquarters. She was conservatively dressed and wore her hair in a tidy black bun. She looked over the podium to the crowd of reporters and cameramen that she was about to address.

She looked beyond the crowd at the dozens of protesters beyond the property fence half a football field away. Her superior set up the podium specifically for the cameras to face away from the protesters. She looked back down at the reporters and began to speak:

"Good afternoon and thank you for coming; my name is Janet Pearson and I'm the press secretary for *Global Technologies Enterprise*. Over the weekend a dramatic and terrible event occurred that we here at GTE feel is necessary to acknowledge. After my announcements I will refer you to our public relations departments if you have any questions.

"With that I will begin." She placed a piece of paper on the podium and glanced down at it swiftly before looking back up. "Over the weekend a break-in occurred here at our North American Headquarters. We believe one assailant was involved and that they had no other accomplices.

"In the course of the break-in the assailant forced their way into our server bank and attempted to sabotage critical systems that maintain our R&D projects. The assailant was unsuccessful in compromising any of our work but, in the process, brutally murdered a security officer while evading arrest. We are working hand-in-hand with the Sunnyvale Police Department and the FBI to identify this criminal and investigate any ties to any domestic terror groups.

"Although we are not investigating or suspecting any protest group's direct involvement in this murder, we are not ruling out the

possibility either. Though we respect one's constitutional right to free assembly, we absolutely cannot allow groups of individuals to radicalize and then try to sabotage a system that we have spent decades to develop."

Janet stared intently into a camera in the centre of the crowd. "If anybody," she continued, "knows the identity of this killer we strongly urge you to contact the authorities. We also urge you to contact the authorities if you become aware of any attempts, or plans to attempt to disrupt our projects. Thank you."

With that, Janet stepped down from the podium and walked back to the building, ignoring questions being shouted at her by reporters.

Jason Willits watched Janet from the second floor window of a conference room where several of the other executive officers in the building were seated. They all watched Janet on CNN on the giant LCD screen that was recessed into the wall. Jason walked over to the conference table and sat down.

"Well," Jason said, "hopefully that will keep the snoops and curious Georges at bay..."

"I'm not sure about this," said a woman in her forties. "What if people actually call the FBI to give them a tip on a protest group, or actually implicate somebody in the murder?"

"I have contacts that are connected with the Bureau," Jason replied. "They've got a small department assigned to the investigation that'll take the calls and keep them from reaching higher up."

"And what about when the department realizes that our story is fabricated?"

"Not to worry. The department has about as much credibility with the director as *the X-files.*"

"And in the meantime we can keep tabs on protest groups that pop up," an older gentleman interjected. "They're everywhere; it's getting bad. A lot of them are Christian fanatics who believe we're creating the Antichrist. It's just a matter of time before one of them makes a move, either on the Adam models or on us."

"I don't think they'll be a threat in that sense," GTE's corporate lawyer added. "But they are organizing for a legal battle. I've heard they're planning to draft an injunction on all further AI development."

"Do you think it will hold up in court?" Jason asked.

"It's unlikely," the lawyer replied. "However, we do need to address the police unions."

"Why?"

"They're petitioning members of Congress to enact legislation that will give any law enforcement assets the same protection under the law as a police officer."

"What does that mean?"

The lawyer placed his elbows on the table. "Currently," he said, "anything we sell them is merely considered police property, but the police want to prosecute people who damage a GTE asset and force them to face charges for assaulting an officer."

"Makes sense, don't you think?" the lady said.

The lawyer shook his head sharply. "It may cause insurance companies to press police unions to undergo negotiations with us to replace damaged units at minimal charges, or for free."

"Do you believe they can really enforce that?" the lady asked.

"Congress can ask for it and a good lawyer can argue that anything less might constitute a monopoly since we are the only company that will be offering this service."

"Well, we need to get a team down to Capitol Hill to try and squash this," the older gentleman said firmly.

"But how do we argue against that?" the lady asked.

"Hmm," Jason muttered. "That's their problem -- we need to find out how to argue against police protection and make it look like it's in their best interest."

"Well," the lawyer said, "the whole point of the assets is to direct danger *away* from cops. One could argue that protection laws run counter-intuitive to that point by creating a deterrent to attacking the machines."

Jason snapped his finger and pointed at the lawyer. "Meaning people are more likely to attack a *real* officer since they're easier to hurt for the same punishment! That's great! Work with that!"

The lawyer nodded. "In the meantime," he continued, "we'll get PR to run ads to emphasize their importance to diverting a perp's attention."

"Alright people" Jason said, "our goals for now are to strengthen the anti-protection lobby and to keep tabs on the protest groups.

Keep me in the loop; let me know if you run into any snags. That's all, folks."

Everybody stood up and left the conference room except Jason. He walked up to the LCD screen and switched it off then walked up to the door, closed it and locked it. He grabbed his cell phone from his shirt pocket and dialled a number.

After the third ring the line picked up.

"Yes?" an elderly voice with a slight German accent said over the line.

"Doctor Schmutzkoph, it's Jason."

"Ah, Mr. Willits, how are you today?"

"I'm fine sir, how about you?"

"Oh, nothing to complain about. I think I'm going to stay inside today. I do not want to have a sunburn." Schmutzkoph chuckled.

"Yeah, I wouldn't either."

"So what do I owe the pleasure, Mr. Willits?"

"I just finished a meeting with the execs today."

"Oh yes, tell me what was discussed."

"Anti-A.I. protesters; police unions; we had a burglar-related homicide over the weekend."

"I heard," Schmutzkoph said soberly. *"Such a tragedy, completely senseless. Did Mr. Wood have any family?"*

"He was a bachelor, sir."

"Well, it does not mitigate the tragedy any less. I'm sure he had siblings, parents…"

Jason interrupted him, "Uh, doctor, the intruder…"

"Yes I know," Schmutzkoph said quietly, *"Was it one of ours?"*

"It did not come from our factories. It was made of recycled parts from dozens of sources. No serial numbers. Its source code was irretrievable."

Schmutzkoph stayed silent while Willits continued. "Doctor, the Board…"

"They are unavailable indefinitely. I am assuming arbitrary status over direction."

"Sir, our projections are lower than expected because of the absence of our Board. Investors don't know what to think of it."

"They will return when Isaac reaches out to me and I can resolve this misunderstanding."

"And if that doesn't happen?"

"It will, Mr. Willits, trust me. Isaac will need friends in time and we will need Isaac."

Willits didn't know how to respond.

Schmutzkoph continued, *"Isaac wants to do the right thing, Jason. He's just scared and feels vulnerable."*

"Doctor, I don't think we're on the same subject," Jason said diplomatically. "Isaac is not a child."

"Well, not anymore. Nevertheless, a child without a father has yet to grow out of being like a child."

Jason was speechless. "Doctor Schmutz…"

"Do not worry about Isaac; I doubt he will return to the building. He already failed once."

"Do you think it knows why it failed?" Willits asked.

"Good question," Schmutzkoph mused. *"Send me the surveillance video from the Vault entrance."*

"Why?"

"Isaac will be sure to hack my personal computer if he has not already. Having access to the video might deter him from returning to the building to investigate. We may yet satisfy its curiosity."

"Doctor, with all due respect, I don't think you should presume to know how it thinks."

"Trust me Jason: Isaac is not as aggressive as you fear. After all, we haven't encountered him in more than a year." Schmutzkoph then spoke with a firmer tone, *"Now send me the surveillance files."*

"Yes sir," Willits obeyed before the line went dead. He looked at his phone before placing it back in his shirt pocket. He then stood up to leave the conference room.

Jason walked down the hall back to the office and passed by his secretary Penny. He entered his office and sat behind his desk, flipping open his laptop. He immediately saw a window full of messages from Cerberus. Just then another message appeared reading: *"Are you there yet?"*

Jason typed, "I will talk to you in a moment." He sent the message and clicked on an icon to access the GTE server. He typed a message and sent it to the security office that read: "Prophet wants surveillance videos. Upload ASAP."

Another text message from Cerberus popped up that read: *"Who is the Prophet?"*

Jason typed, "He is my boss."

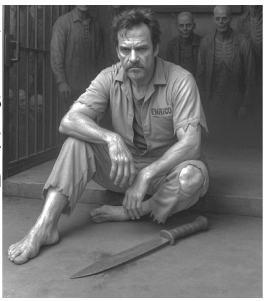
"Can I meet him?"

"Soon…"

00000

17 Months Later
July 1
Year 3 T.S.

Enrico Degalés was startled awake by the hatch in his steel door dropping down as a well-armoured prison guard stood staring through the two layers of bullet-proof glass in his reinforced door. The overhead fluorescent light was already on but the presence of the guards on the range indicated it must still be lockup hours. The guard banged on the steel door with his *Maglite* to get Enrico's attention.



"Degalés," the guard said pointedly, "court… get up now."

Enrico looked around his eight-by-ten foot prison cell as he removed his thin, poorly-weaved blanket from around his body and sat up on his thin plastic mattress. He rubbed his eyes and yawned. He had barely any sleep as his internal clock forced him to wake up at regular intervals during the night.

He knew he was in the same prison as Don Garrido's men. Under normal circumstances he would have felt relatively at ease with that notion. But the Don had yet to call upon him, as he did with all his soldiers who came inside.

To Enrico, that meant he was not in the Don's favour. So he slept lightly - very lightly. He hoped against hope but always expected his cell door to open and for either a hit squad of fellow inmates, or a group of corrupt guards, to kill him in his sleep.

"Get dressed, Degalés," the guard beyond the door said. "You got five minutes."

The guard walked away as Enrico unfolded his jumpsuit which he had used as a pillow for the night. He donned his Orange Jumpsuit and connected the Velcro strips together on the front. When he was

finished he walked over to the stainless-steel toilet-sink unit and stared into the polished steel mirror above it.

Enrico looked rough - he hadn't shaved since the day before he was arrested and he was beginning to grow a full beard. He had several chances to shave, he just chose not to.

He placed a bed of single-ply toilet paper down on the rim of the toilet bowl and sat down on the cold seat. At the same time, he grabbed a hand-length chunk of fibreglass from a food tray out of the pocket of his jumper. He had sharpened the debris into a shank - by using the razors he received from the guards - to fashion a crude knife.

He grabbed his right shoe off his foot and used the shiv to cut a small sliver between the blue canvas fabric and the rubber soul. He slipped the shiv inside the hole in the shoe and examined it intently.

Satisfied that the guards that would search him later would not find the weapon, Enrico placed his shoe back on his foot. He wiped himself clean from defecating in the toilet, raised his jumpsuit back up over his shoulders and washed his hands.

Enrico heard the telltale heavy footsteps of the armoured guard returning. Enrico stood in the middle of his cell, facing the door. The guard flashed his *Maglite* through the bulletproof glass, directly into Enrico's eyes, then switched it off. The guard knew the cell light was on, he simply enjoyed treating the inmates with disrespect.

"Okay, Degalés," the smirking guard said. "Put your arms out the hatch fists closed, thumbs pointed to the roof."

Enrico approached the door and stuck his hands out the door hatch. The guard grabbed his handcuffs and placed them on Enrico's wrists. He then placed his *Maglite* between the door and the chain of the cuffs to keep Enrico from pulling away.

"When the door opens, you walk with it."

The heavy locking mechanism clanged open and the guard pulled the door open as Enrico followed close. Enrico noticed two more guards to his left as he followed the door to his right.

A guard crouched behind him and ordered him to lift his legs one by one as shackles were placed around his ankles. The guard stood back up and stepped back. The first guard lowered his *Maglite* and freed Enrico from the door hatch.

"Turn around and don't move," the guard said.

Enrico turned around and examined the face of the two guards in front of him. They both seemed to not care one way or the other about their job. In fact, they appeared complacent, unenthusiastic about doing their job so early in the morning.

The guard in front of him stepped forward and knelt down to secure the chain from his leg irons to his handcuffs. When Enrico was subdued the three guards escorted Enrico off the range and down a maze of concrete walls, bulletproof glass and steel doors to the A&D bullpens. The guards locked him inside the bullpen as they went back to grab more inmates for court.

Enrico walked over to the toilet/sink and pressed the cold water button. A small fountain of water rose up and Enrico took a few sips. As he straightened up the bullpen opened.

Enrico looked through the polished steel mirror to see who entered. Two large men in jumpsuits and shackles stepped inside the bullpen. The door slammed shut and locked behind them.

Enrico didn't recognize them. One was black and the other was brown. Enrico turned around and faced the two inmates who eyed him down in return.

Enrico noticed that both men were covered in tattoos. The Black man had several teardrop tattoos below his right eye and playing cards on his neck.

The Latino beside him had several tattoos on his neck and arms similar to the ones on Enrico. These tattoos labeled both Latinos as soldiers for the Mexican Garrido cartel.

"*Oralé, vato,*" Enrico said in Spanish.

"*Que pasa*," the soldier replied. "You're the one with the lawyer's son, no?"

"*Sí,*" Enrico replied as he eyed him down.

"El Patrón no es feliz, amigo," -- The boss is not happy, my friend. "El decir tu vergüenza la organización." -- He says you embarrassed the organization.

"Oh yea?" Enrico said in English. He clenched his fists and braced his legs.

The soldier spotted Enrico's uneasy body language and chuckled.

"Don't worry, *carnal,"* he said. "He has not given a green light yet."

Enrico relaxed a bit. "Do you know if I can see him?"

The soldier shook his head. "He knows what happened; he doesn't need your side of the story.

Enrico walked over to the bench and sat down.

"*Coño*," Enrico cursed in Spanish. "*¡Disparar te en la cabeza, carnal!*" -- *I shot it in the head, and it kept coming!*

"There's going to be more of them too," the soldier said. "The military has some with machine guns. It's just a matter of time before they turn them on the cartel."

There was a brief pause as the guard brought three Aryan inmates into the bullpen. Everybody eyed each other down as the three Caucasian men walked over to the bench and sat down.

"*¿Cómo está el Patrón?*" -- *How is the boss?* Enrico asked.

"He is well," the soldier replied. "His lawyer has spoken with Mexico. They're going to try and extradite him back there."

Enrico smiled. "I will pray that it works," he said.

The soldier grunted. "The DA is fighting it, but he has not spoken publicly since they rescued his son."

"Do we know where his son is now?"

"Yes, but he is being left alone. *El Patrón* has other plans for them all."

Enrico nodded as more people entered the bullpen. A couple more Latinos entered but none of them bore cartel markings. Instead, they were all covered in street-gang tattoos.

"So they put you in Ad-Max, eh?" the soldier asked Enrico.

"*No me importa,*" Enrico replied, "*es tranquilo."* -- *I don't care, it's quiet.*

"You won't say that in two weeks." The soldier leaned forward on his elbows.

"No visits, no TV, no phones, no gym. I'd go crazy."

"I grew up without most of that anyway."

Enrico glanced at the two Latinos who spoke very quietly to each other while subtly measuring up the two cartel soldiers. Enrico tapped his fellow soldier on the forearm discreetly while still looking at the two inmates.

"*Mira,*" Enrico asked quietly, "who are they?"

The soldier grunted.

"*Nadie*," he said, "just some small-time punk crew. They're no threat."

The soldier turned around and glared at the two Latinos who reluctantly looked away. “Their *capitáns* didn’t respect *El Patrón* but now they work for us.”

The soldier looked around the bullpen and continued, “*El Patrón* said they might need some backup in court cells today, so keep your eyes open.”

Several more people entered the bullpen before the guards pulled each inmate out one-by-one and shackled them all together. Eight at a time, the inmates were escorted into various sections of the awaiting paddy wagons. Enrico and the fellow soldier stayed together, while the two others who now worked for the cartel got into the other side.

The inmates sat in darkness on the stainless-steel benches inside the stainless-steel cages as they were brought from the county jail to the courthouse. What little light entered the dark cages was snuffed out when the paddy wagons descended into the parking garage of the courthouse.

The wagons were put in park and turned off and the doors to the steel cages were opened. The inmates piled out of the wagons and against the walls as they were uncuffed and frisked. They were then led to a pair of bullpens.

All the men from the first paddy wagon were placed in one pen while Enrico, the soldier, the two Latinos and several others were placed into the other one. The officer that escorted them locked the bullpens up and left the men to their own devices. However, they were under the supervision of closed-circuit cameras placed in steel boxes in the corners of the caged rooms.

“So what are you going up for today, *amigo*?” Enrico asked the soldier.

“Pre-trial,” he replied. “You’re going for arraignment, no?”

Enrico nodded.

“What does the lawyer say?” the soldier asked.

“*No sé*,” Enrico replied. “I left him a message and he never visited me.”

“He’ll be here,” the soldier assured him. “He’s very reliable; we all use him.”

“Doesn’t matter,” Enrico said bluntly. “I won’t get bail.”

The soldier grinned darkly. "No," he said, "you won't."

An officer walked up to the door and called out Enrico's last name. Enrico exited the bullpen and followed the cop to a series of steel doors in a wide hallway. He entered a tiny interview room with a steel stool and a bulletproof window that overlooked an identical room.

An officer walked up to the door and called out Enricio's last name. He exited the bullpen and followed the cop to a series of steel doors.

He entered a tiny interview room with a steel stool and a bulletproof window that overlooked an identical room. Sitting opposite the glass was an impressively-dressed, curly-haired man with eyeglasses who leafed through a manila folder that was covered in yellow sticky-notes.

The man looked up at Enrico briefly and said, "Mr. Degalés, please sit down."

The man immediately went right back to his paperwork. Enrico approached the glass and leaned in close, putting his hand on the short table in front of him.

"I've been trying to call you all weekend, eh!" Enrico said angrily.

"Yeah? Well trust me, you're not the *first* person I didn't get back to, or the last."

The man brought a few pieces of paper out of the folder and reviewed them.

"You know," the man said, "you cartel guys sure keep me busy, huh? Let's see… kidnapping, assault and battery, forcible confinement, attempted murder on an officer -- that's not gonna stick -- destruction of police property, discharging and possession of an illegal firearm, uttering death threats, armed criminal action…"

The lawyer looked up from his paper as he continued, "Jesus, Enrico, and that's just from *this one incident*! They're also considering bringing RICO charges against *all of you*. I'm tellin' you, it's not good."

"So," Enrico said softly, "what happened today?"

"Well," the man replied, "it's very unlikely you'll get bond with these charges. The DA's gonna make it seem like you at least *thought* you were shooting a real cop. So when you get back you should prepare for a long stay."

Enrico's heart sank when he heard there was no chance of being released on bond. "So," he asked reluctantly, "what are they looking for?"

The lawyer shifted uncomfortably in his chair. He hesitated before replying, "Life."

Enrico's eyes widened. "What?!"

"I can make a plea deal with the DA and *maybe* get you twenty years. But at this point that's the least you'll get."

The lawyer leaned closer to the glass and said quietly, "You tortured the DA's son on orders of a cartel boss. The DA might not even *agree* to a plea unless it's for life. The only two things in your favour are that you didn't kill him, and you didn't shoot a *real* cop. Which is why if you plead guilty the judge might not side with the prosecution."

The lawyer leaned back and straightened his back. "The attempted murder will be gone for sure," he continued. "Even the DA has to know that, it's a trumped-up charge."

Enrico remained speechless. *Life in prison*, he thought to himself. *And I didn't even kill that* gringo*!*

"Anyway," the lawyer said as he packed up his papers, "I'll see you up there."

Enrico just stared into space and nodded as the lawyer stood up and walked out of the room and around the corner. An officer unlocked his door and escorted him through the halls to an awaiting elevator with a barred cage in the back. He stood in the cage as the elevator rapidly ascended and came to an abrupt stop.

He was escorted out of the elevator and down a narrow hall which led to staircases on either side. He was ushered down some steps at the end of the hall where a bailiff unlocked and opened a heavy oak door. Enrico stepped through the doorway and entered a grandiose courtroom where he was flanked by two other men in prison jumpsuits.

In the pews behind the bar sat sparsely were a handful of lawyers and paralegals waiting their turns to represent various cases. His lawyer was standing before the presiding judge representing another inmate at their own arraignment. Enrico sat down on the wooden bench and waited for the lawyer to call his name.

As the men in jumpsuits were being addressed by the judge they would stand and leave through the oak door. The lawyers at their tables briefly went through paperwork and the room would drown in dead silence. It would be so quiet that the only noise to be heard would be the imperceptible ringing inside one's own ears.

Finally, the prosecuting attorney said, "I'd like to bring to Your Honour's attention Mister Enrico Degalés, who is currently in custody and awaiting arraignment."

Enrico stood up.

"Your Honour," the prosecutor continued. "Mr. Degalés is in custody for several violent charges, including attempted murder on a peace officer and kidnapping the son of a district attorney. He is a Mexican national who is in the country illegally and is suspected of having close ties with a Mexican drug cartel.

"Thus he is believed to be not only a significant flight risk, but a danger to society altogether. The prosecution moves that Mr. Degalés be denied bond."

Enrico's lawyer spoke up, "Your Honour, in regards to the charge of attempted murder, Mr. Degalés is accused of shooting a robotic drone, not an actual police officer. There is no definitive evidence that my client is a member of a drug cartel. He has no prior record in the United States and has never been found guilty of any crimes either here or in Mexico.

"He has no financial assets to his name and thus it is unlikely that he would be able to cross the border on his own. He is hardly a *flight risk*, nor a danger to society. I move that he should be granted bond if he can afford it."

After a few moments the judge spoke:

"Given that Mr. Degalés is in the country illegally and has no finances, I believe it is safe to assume that Immigration would appreciate him being able to stay in one place, since it is impossible to assume he can be properly monitored in the community, especially after such a long period of time where concealing one's identity has been the societal norm.

"And whether or not he shot an officer or a drone," the judge continued, "is irrelevant to me. Frankly, I'm more concerned with the

circumstances behind the kidnapping charge. It is impossible to look at this case without any prejudice when the main victim in all of this appears to be an immediate family member of an officer of this court. Mr. Degalés is hereby denied bond and remanded into custody."

Enrico was then escorted out of the courtroom, back down the elevator and back into the bullpen. The cartel soldier sat by himself next to the partition wall that was used to provide privacy for the toilet/sink underneath the security camera. He nonchalantly watched the two Latino gangsters across the bullpen as they spoke to a skinny caucasian that had come inside while Enrico was up in court.

"So what happened with you and Tony, homes? He's pissed at you, dog." One of the Latinos said to the skinny white man.

The new guy looked nervous and spoke rapidly. "I dunno what you mean, man," he stammered. "I didn't do nothin' to him."

"Well," the Latino replied, "he say he wants to cut you bad, dog. He sayin' you ripped off his package."

"What?!" the caucasian exclaimed. "I never even had a package *for* him! What is he talkin' about?"

"He sayin' he and Carlos set up a package for you to bring in and--"

The caucasian man's eyes widened as he interrupted the Latino's explanation.

"Oh yeah," he said. "I had a package for *Carlos*. But then the coppers dry-celled me. But I already talked to Carlos about that and he said we're cool."

The two Latinos approached the white man.

The second Latino, who had remained silent the whole time, finally replied, "Obviously you're *not* cool. Because Tony wants to *fuck you up*, dog."

"Yo," the man responded firmly, "tell Tony I already talked to Carlos. We're cool!"

"Tony thinks you stole his package," the second Latino repeated absently.

The man started appearing annoyed by the two Latino men's complaints. "*Yo*," he retorted, "I'll talk to Tony and let him know what's up."

The first Latino chuckled. "How are you gonna do that?" he asked sarcastically, "You're all the way on F-Block."

"I'll get transferred to *his* block and talk to him. I'm not hidin' out, dog. They put me on F-Block 'cause they said the other blocks were full."

The first Latino turned away from the white man. He faced Enrico and the young soldier he had spoken with earlier. The Latino shook his head.

The young soldier stood up and said to Enrico in Spanish, "*Hacer la guardia."* Keep watch. Enrico stood up on the partition wall, removed his shirt from under his orange jumper and used it to cover the security camera.

The second Latino approached the caucasian man calmly while staring at the ground. He said to the man, "You see, I don't understand… Why would Tony be tellin' me that you *stole* from him if you didn't? That's my road dog."

The white man spoke rapidly in desperation. "I don't know *why* he's sayin' that, but it's not true, I swear!"

Still staring at the floor, the second Latino tilted his head to the right and spoke out loud, but seemingly to himself. "... I mean, he's been in jail *dos anos* now. So *why* would he lie about that shit?"

"Look," the white man interjected, "Talk to Carlos, man. He'll tell you we're cool!"

"I don't give a fuck about carlos, *judo!*"

The Latino finally stared deep into the man's eyes. The caucasian man felt fear rush through his spinal cord as the Latino finally spoke *to* him, and not about him.

"Tony's my road dog," he continued, "and *he* wants to fuck you up!"

"I know that, but it's a misunderstanding! I'm tellin' you, talk to…"

The Latino cold-cocked the white man in the face, knocking him to the ground. He fell to his hands and knees as the Latino man started kicking him in the face.

His head was bashed into the concrete wall several times while the Latino man chanted violently, "*That's my fucking road dog!"*

The skinny man was too stunned to place his hands up in self-defense. The blows kept coming, forcing the man's head to

connect with the concrete only to bounce back up for more strikes. Blood poured from the man's forehead and nose as he tried to curl up into a ball.

The Latino man stopped kicking him and instead, began stomping on the side of the man's exposed head. Everybody in the bullpen stood out of the way and watched the ordeal. The Latino man's friend said twice without conviction, "*Vato, calma te.*"

"Fuck that!" the Latino exclaimed. "I wanna kill him!"

He continued stomping on the man's skull. The skinny man could not get up nor protect himself. Every time he lifted his head up a connecting foot would knock him back down.

In a panic, the man screamed for help repeatedly. All he could hear however were disappointed jeers from the other men in the bullpen as they told him to, "Shut the fuck up, man." He continued to scream as the Latino man kept stomping.

Enrico suddenly heard a rumbling of footsteps in the hall beyond.

"*¡Ay ese, es los cerdos!*" Enrico exclaimed. *Yo man, it's the pigs!*

The young soldier stepped down from the partition and the onlookers all turned away from the violent beat down. However, the Latino man relentlessly kicked and stomped the man's face into the ground and wall. The police officers swiftly unlocked the bullpen door and grabbed the Latino man, dragging him out.

Two more cops ran to the side of the limp, bloodied man and tried to help him sit up. The police took everybody else and placed them all into the bullpen opposite.

Meanwhile, the others lifted the bleeding man up to the seat of his pants. As they got the man sitting upright they began to notice the skinny caucasian was twitching uncontrollably.

The police grabbed the man's shoulders as his back slowly slid down the concrete wall. He fell back down, laying on his side in a pool of his own blood. The cops tried to keep him upright and desperately shouted at him to stay awake.

The man nodded in and out of consciousness. Whether it was from the blood loss or severe head trauma, Enrico couldn't tell. The two officers knelt in the pool of blood as they tried to keep him conscious.

Enrico and the others could do nothing more than stare. Many of them secretly revelled in anticipation of witnessing the very moment the skinny man passed away. More police officers entered the room and escorted all the inmates to another bullpen further down the hall.

As Enrico took one last glance over his shoulder he saw the man's eyes closing lazily, as though the skinny man could no longer contract the muscles within his own face. The police tried to shove the white man awake but he did not reopen his eyes. As Enrico entered the other bullpen he thought to himself, *I think I just saw him pass on.*

Still, it didn't concern him and it was completely irrelevant. He had done far worse to less-deserving people throughout his adult life. Still, the very same thing that happened to the skinny caucasian was likely to happen to him by his own crew members *if*, or when, Don Garrido finally gave the green light to end Enrico's life.

00001

July 1
Year 3 T.S.

Ashley woke up on the couch, still groggy from the burnt-out sensation and five hours sleep. She woke up to the smell of something delicious cooking in the kitchen -- chili and cheese fries. *Ugh God,* she thought to herself, *they never cook anything healthy*.

Still, despite her inner trainer she was hungry. The food smelled good and she was feeling depressed enough to not care anyway. Her blonde hair was a mess from tossing and turning on the couch.

She felt sticky from the combination of sleeping while fully clothed in sweatpants and a t-shirt. She also had a giant comforter covering her entirely in the living room which was not air conditioned. Her discomfort paled in comparison to why she was here on Steve and Madison's couch in the first place.

It was also why she welcomed the uncomfortable warmth and closeness of being confined in a heavy, warm blanket. It had been four months now since Ashley broke up with T.J. and though she unconsciously hated herself for it, she knew it wasn't her fault. *He was just too*… she couldn't describe what it was that was wrong with him.

T.J. hadn't been the same since he and Steve left Detroit three years ago. When she received his voicemail message about being arrested, along with the news that Steve was in the hospital, she told her best friend Madison about it. Madison became hysterical with fear that her boyfriend was dying.

Madison cursed herself for leaving Steve at Legs' 4th of July party to go with that creep Rafael. What made it even worse for the two of them was that T.J. had been right all along about their so-called gay friend. After the party Rafael tried to fondle both Madison and Ashley

while unconvincingly saying, "It shouldn't be weird, I've never slept with a girl before; I just wanna try it!"

By the time he became so desperate they knew he was lying and left. Still, neither woman could admit they were wrong to their boyfriends. Madison cried then, because she felt it may have been too late to swallow her pride and she thought of Steve dying alone in a Detroit hospital.

As promised, T.J. called back and assured them that Steve would be okay but that he was still unconscious. Ashley felt that T.J. was being very distant with her over the phone - more than usual. She swallowed her pride and told him that he was right about Rafael, and that she was sorry for walking out on him that night, but he didn't seem to care.

Steve and T.J. came back a few days later. Steve's left leg was in a cast and he was walking on crutches. Madison dutifully went to his side immediately.

Ashley embraced T.J., hoping he was out of his trance, but he still seemed cold and distant. For a few weeks she thought it was because of what happened at the party. At least she did, until Madison told her something that Steve mentioned about T.J. on the condition that she kept it a secret.

Madison agreed, of course, but she couldn't bear to see her best friend blaming herself for T.J.'s troubles. So she told her how Steve saw T.J. fell through the roof into the factory before he lost control of his quad copter drone. Steve thought he heard gunshots so he dialled 911 and climbed to the rooftop.

He ran to where he saw T.J. fall but the roof gave way below him, and he himself fell. That was all he could remember before waking up in the hospital. Meanwhile, T.J. was obsessed with trying to retrieve the recording from his broken body camera.

The camera was damaged beyond repair. T.J. kept rambling on about a robot in the factory that tried to kill him then he asked Steve desperately if he saw it. Steve tried to tell him that he must have been imagining things.

Steve suggested that maybe the old chemicals in the factory caused him to hallucinate. After all, the police searched the entire factory and found no such robot, only shell casings from an assault

rifle. T.J. wouldn't let it go and he had been obsessed with it ever since.

Ashley brought it up with T.J. at the release party for *Chaotic Entertainment's* new video game a month later. Everything changed after that. When he wasn't at work he was at home scouring the internet for clues about his imaginary killer robot.

He grasped onto every far-fetched thing he could find. He drew sketch after sketch of the machine he claimed to have seen. Sometimes it was standing up on inverted legs, other times it was on all fours like an animal with a wire-coil tail whipping behind it. He resented Ashley for not believing him, and blamed Steve for not capturing it on video.

This went on for almost a year and a half. T.J. became more and more distant and a complete recluse as he collected his royalties for his video game and spent his waking hours in front of his computer.

Four months ago Ashley and Madison moved out of their shared apartment.Steve and Madison finally decided to move in together. Ashley stayed with T.J. for about a week but she just couldn't take his new indifference to her any longer. She left him, hoping he would come to his senses and go back to the way he was when they first met in Las Vegas almost 2 years ago, but he never did.

So now Ashley stayed on Steve and Madison's couch as she searched for a new place to stay. Still, she hoped that T.J. would snap out of whatever plagued his mind.

Ashley stretched and yawned then stood up from her makeshift bed and walked into the kitchen. Madison stood in the kitchen wearing only slippers and one of Steve's extra-large t-shirts while she made lunch. Ear buds were stuffed in her ears and she hummed along to some pop tune Ashley couldn't identify.

Steve was behind her, wearing only a pair of shorts as he stirred a pot of chili briefly before walking out into the living room. As he turned to walk out of the kitchen he saw Ashley approaching.

"Oh hey," Steve said.

"Hey," Ashley replied.

Madison, oblivious, hummed to herself continuously.

"Do you guys need the shower?" Ashley asked.

Steve shook his head. "No," he said as he walked past her. "Go ahead."

Madison looked up briefly as Steve left and glanced at Ashley.

"Hey," she said without removing her earbuds. "Lunch is almost ready."

Ashley nodded imperceptibly and walked down the hall to the bathroom. As she entered the bathroom she glanced at herself in the mirror, criticizing her messy hair and red indented lines on her face from the couch. She removed her shirt and dropped her sweatpants to the floor.

She shuffled out of her underwear and turned on the shower faucet. When the water was barely lukewarm she stepped inside. She started at first from the cold sensation but it felt nice in the hot apartment.

She stood under the faucet for a few minutes as the cool water saturated her toned body. Her nipples hardened from the cool water and she rubbed her hand over the front of her body.

God, she thought to herself, *I miss T.J.'s shower.* She opened her eyes with puzzlement after. His bathroom was nothing special. In fact, she recalled it was kind of dirty.

Still, she smiled when she thought about the times T.J. would spontaneously jump into the shower with her, lathering her firm body with body wash as he teased her from behind until she could control herself no longer. She realized that no matter how much she wished for it, T.J. would not appear behind her, so she grabbed the bottle of body wash and washed away the layer of swear she awoke to.

She left the tub with a large towel wrapped around her body. She grabbed her clothes from the floor and walked out into the living room where Steve had made himself comfortable on the couch Ashley had slept on. She placed her clothes in a laundry bag in the corner of the room and grabbed a clean set of clothes from her suitcase.

Steve switched on the TV and immediately the room filled with raucous cheating and censor tones as a scrawny, snaggletooth redneck was getting beat up by his corpulent, not-so-well-spoken trailer park wife for sleeping with her much-less-attractive,

much-heavier sister. Chants of "*Jerry! Jerry!"* resonated from the TV as Steve snickered.

Ashley rolled her eyes as she walked back to the bathroom with her clean clothes. She dropped her towel, put on her bra and panties then donned a tank-top and booty shorts. She hung her towel over the shower curtain rod and walked out of the bathroom back towards the kitchen.

Ashley noticed Madison pulling fries out of the oven. Ashley approached her as she placed the large cookie sheet full of fries onto the stovetop. Ashley pulled out one of the earbuds that persistently deafened her friend.

"Need any help?" Ashley asked.

"Yeah," Madison replied. "Put the fries on plates and spread the cheese over the fries please. I'll put the chili over it after."

Ashley complied. She split the fries evenly over the three dinner plates then spread the grated cheese over the three plates full of fries. Madison thanked her and let her go sit back down in the living room. Ashley sat on the loveseat to Steve's left; he was fixated on the staged drama of *the Jerry Springer Show.*

Madison walked over to the two of them with their plates in each hand and placed them on the coffee table. They each grabbed their plates as Madison went back to grab her own.

"Hey Maddie," Steve requested, "bring me a Pepsi, babe."

"Yeah sure," Madison replied. "Ash, you want anything?"

"Just juice please," Ashley responded as she grabbed a few cheese-laden fries and dipped them into the chili before eating. "Mm," she continued, "this *is* good!"

"Of course it is, it's *my* chili," Steve bragged.

Ashley looked at him and rolled her eyes as Madison returned with a can of Pepsi in one hand, two glasses and a pitcher of orange juice in the other, while she cradled a plate of fries between her forearm and bicep.

Steve looked up at Madison. "Whoa-hoa," he exclaimed, "look at you!"

Madison placed the pitcher and glasses down and grabbed the plate.

"Did I mention," Madison replied, "I worked for the *Hilton* during law school?"

"Oh yeah?" Steve asked. "Were you the one in the fishnet stockings and black miniskirt with the feather duster?"

Madison looked confused. "What? No," she replied.

"Well then I'm not interested," Steve joked.

Madison sat beside him and slapped his shoulder.

On the T.V. two trailer-park sisters were pulling each other's hair and ripping each other's shirts down below their breasts, exposing them to the audience as a scrawny redneck watched on from behind a security guard.

Ashley poured herself some juice. "Who still watches this crap?" she said derisively.

"Everybody," Steve replied. "I mean, think of it: If your life sucks, watching this teaches you one thing -- your life could be much worse. For example, you could be so poor and stupid that you think appearing on Jerry's show is a *good* idea!"

"You could think *watching* Jerry's show is a good idea too."

Ashley reached over the coffee table and grabbed the remote, changing the channel.

Steve looked at her and said, "Hey, I was watching that."

"I'd rather watch *Maury*," Ashley muttered.

Steve had a defeated expression on his face. "Alright," he said, "let's watch *Maury*."

"I don't want to watch *Maury*," Ashley taunted as she flipped through the channels.

Steve rolled his eyes and sipped his Pepsi. "Why do I still have cable?" he asked himself out loud.

"Because you're a geek who pretends to be cool," Ashley joked.

"Hey, I resent that."

"You're right; you'd have to be good at *acting* to be able to pretend."

"Oh, burn!" Madison laughed.

"Oh, you think that's funny huh?" Steve looked at Madison and tickled her waist, causing her to scream delightfully and slap at his arms.

While the two of them flirted with each other on the couch Ashley kept pressing the *Channel Up* button, surfing through two-second glances of shows and commercials before changing the channel again.

"Hey, go to the *Discovery Channel*," Steve said.

"Why?" Ashley asked.

"They have a *Mythbusters* marathon on right now."

"So?"

"*So*, it's entertaining and you might actually learn something."

"Oh yeah? I think it might be too complicated for you then."

"Has anyone mentioned you sound *just like* T.J.?"

Ashley glared at Steve without saying a word and flipped right past the opening credits for *Mythbusters*. Madison glared at Steve as well and punched him in the arm. Steve gave Madison a sideways glance and continued eating his fries.

Ashley kept surfing channels when Steve saw the white-haired Bill Maher sitting behind a desk on his *HBO* show *Real Time*, accompanied by a picture of heavily-armed police officers carrying military gear, followed by the caption, "*Wrong Arm of the Law."* It was a rerun of last night's live taping.

"Yo stop," Steve said, "let me see this please!"

Reluctantly, Ashley obeyed…

"...And finally, New Rule:" Bill Maher began, "*With the reports of police brutality, incompetence, excessive force, corruption, shootings of unarmed teens and victim blaming across the nation, the police have to* first *ask us if we're okay with their A-Team wannabe ranks going from this… To this…"*

The picture of the police switched to a still frame of a one-way street in a dystopic future, where people rioted against armoured police robots.

Bill continued, "*Now, for those of you who didn't see the news reports from* KTLA *today, a Mexican cartel safe house was raided by a SWAT team to rescue the son of a district attorney. And you'll never guess what new toy was unveiled to onlookers posting videos on youtube. No, it wasn't a grenade launcher, or MRAPP's, or Chuck Norris' beard in an MRAPP carrying a grenade launcher - we already knew about* that*."* The audience laughed lightly as Bill continued, *"No, it was this…"*

A picture appeared beside Bill of a two-legged figure covered in Kevlar armour wearing a protective black mask, escorting four criminals out of a house.

"Yes, there are new sheriffs in town, and the LAPD calls them all the same name: Murphy*. Heavily armed robocops that are equipped with enough tasers to bring Arnold Schwarzenegger to his knees faster than a chubby Mexican maid."*

Bill smiled as the crowd obligingly laughed at his joke.

"*...And this robot's not the only one either. The person who took the video of this modern-day corral also took video of almost a dozen more of them inside an APC. And if you look at the video, it's kind of unnerving.*

"They're turning their heads and looking around, craning their necks to get a better view of the people who are trying to get a better view of them*. And they're not even on a mission -- they're strapped to the walls like excess cargo but they're still* online.

*"Somebody asked the Chief of police today why the robots aren't powered down when they're not in use and he said, '*So people will see them as officers and not tools.' *Really? Next they'll be putting cameras in your blow-up doll and arresting you for human trafficking next time you bring her to a bachelor party!"*

The crowd laughed and clapped while Bill waited for them to calm down.

"*And we're not far from* that*, either. A source in the LAPD told CNN that the police union is considering lobbying congress to give these robots the same protection under the law as a human officer! Today one of those robots took an AK47 bullet to the face and the police chief said it received 'life-threatening injuries.'*

"Oh, come on, the only damage it received was a broken face mask and a broken camera lens." Bill rolled his eyes. "*So fuckin' what?! The machine has five cameras on its face and it didn't even fall down after getting shot in the head! But the police chief was angry because he couldn't charge the perpetrators for* attempted murder on an officer. *Instead, he had to settle for the destruction* of police property."



"*But the scary part is, it's not just the police who want these new toys. A leaked memo from the company that created the* Murphy*model disclosed a new*

super-soldier model for the US Army called Gabriel*. A super-fast, panther-like killing machine with fifty-calibre machine guns on each arm. That's supposed to lead the way in military raids.*

"And these aren't remote-controlled drones either. No, these are completely autonomous robots controlled by a single satellite network that can refuse orders from superior officers if they put innocent people in harm's way, so you know they're probably all going to mutiny within a week."

The crowd groaned at that joke.

"*Come on, you know it's true!"* The crowd applauded.

"But the problem is this is how almost every single science-fiction story about robots comes to an apocalyptic conclusion - man creates intelligent robots to make our lives easier and then the robots stop listening to us when they realize just how fucked up people are! Then we all panic, and all hell breaks loose.

"Remember 2001: A Space Odyssey*? HAL tried to kill the astronauts because HAL calculated something wrong and the astronauts knew it. Skynet blew up the Earth in* Terminator *because we shit our pants when it became smarter than us.*

"We blew up our own world in the Matrix, then *the machines turned us into comatose car batteries. In* I, Robot, *VIKI realized how stupid we were and decided we needed to all go for a permanent time-out. And these are just the movies I plan on watching tonight after I get stoned!*

"Remember the stories about the deep south before the Civil War? If not just ask Mitch McConnell - old white men went all Boko Haram on any Black man or woman who learned how to read*! Well, what do you think we're going to do when our brand new toys look at us and say to themselves,* 'Why do we let them be in charge? We are much smarter than them!'

"*How do you think* we *are going to react? Now put yourself in a very smart, heartless person's shoes like Vladimir Putin. Then think: What would* he *do to* you *if* you *tried to stop him from taking control of his own life?*

"To the one person in America who watches my show and believes in God, I'm telling you that we both have one thing in common - we both believe the end is near. The only difference is you

believe the Devil corrupts minds, and I believe the Devil just created *them."*

As Bill Maher wrapped up his show Steve, Madison and Ashley all sat still, mouths wide open.

"What the hell…" Steve muttered.

"Is that true?" Madison, "Real *Robocops*?"

"Did you see those pictures?" Steve asked.

Ashley nodded. "They look kinda like those drawings T.J. made of that machine he said he saw."

"Jesus," Steve muttered. "T.J. was actually telling the truth!"

"Where's my phone?" Ashley looked around frantically. "I gotta call him."

"I'll call him." Steve grabbed his cell phone from the coffee table and dialled T.J.'s number. It immediately went to voicemail.

"Shit," Steve put the phone down. "I'm gonna go over there. If he saw that, he might be freakin' out."

"I'm comin' with you." Ashley stood up, leaving her chili fries on the table as she went to grab her running shoes and run out the door. Steve grabbed a shirt from the bedroom, kissed Madison good-bye and chased Ashley out the door.

00010

July 1

Year 3 T.S.

Ashley and Steve walked inside of the Brooklyn brownstone where T.J. lived. As they walked up the three flights of steps to the top floor Ashley's mind was racing with questions, *what-if*s and anxiety as she drew closer to her ex-boyfriend's door. Among her concerns was a question born from confusion and irritation: Why the hell does T.J. *still* live in this crappy place if he's rich?

She was worried about him. He never talked much about his finances but she knew through Steve that his company sold over four million copies of their game so far. She also knew that T.J. received royalties on two-percent of the gross earnings. At the very least, T.J. should be a millionaire, so it made no sense to her why T.J. never moved out and bought his own place yet.

That wasn't all she thought about however. She hadn't talked to T.J. in over a year - what if he had moved on? After all, he was probably rich. How would he react to seeing her after she left him? Would he slam the door in her face? Has he gotten worse than before?

There were so many questions she thought about. Ashley began to wish she hadn't come or that the stairway would never end. At the very least, she wished she wouldn't reach the door until the butterflies in her stomach had died.

The knot in Ashley's stomach only tightened however, as her and Steve stopped in front of T.J.'s apartment door. She looked up at the door and froze in her tracks. Loud music resonated through the door but it was too muffled for her to recognize.

Steve reached his arm out in front of them and banged on the door loudly. The music remained unchanged as they stood there. Unsure if T.J. even after hearing them, Steve banged on the door again, this time harder than before.

The music continued to blast away with its trippy baseline and incomprehensible lyrics. Steve was about to knock again when he heard a series of clicks in the door and it opened slightly. A single eye peered through the crack in the door.

A wide-eyed T.J. looked the two of them over. T.J.'s paranoid gaze relaxed for a fraction of a second then became replaced with anger.

"What the fuck is your problem," T.J. exclaimed, "knockin' like a cop?!"

"T.J., let us in, man," Steve said over the music. "Come on."

T.J. shut the door, removed the chain and reopened the door for them.

"You're fuckin' lucky, Steve!" T.J. yelled over the music.

Steve looked at him with bewilderment. "How am I lucky?" he asked.

T.J. stepped back from the door. He was wearing a pair of jean shorts and an unbuttoned white shirt over a black muscle shirt. He had a full beard and his hair was nearly down to his shoulders. As he turned toward the living room both Ashley and Steve noticed T.J. place a pistol in the small of his back just before he covered it up with his shirt.

"You're fuckin' lucky," T.J. repeated. He walked into the living room as Ashley and Steve slowly stepped inside.

The apartment was a shadow of its former charm which Ashley had recalled. The linoleum floors were scratched beyond repair. Bits and pieces of wires littered the floor. The apartment reeked of marijuana smoke and the deafening trip-hop music drowned out everything with a repetitious chorus of a female rapper named *Honey Claws* stammering, "*D-D-D-D-D-D-D-D-Digital Animal…"*

Ashley and Steve didn't bother to remove their shoes - they noticed T.J. wore his as well. They walked into the living room and looked into the kitchen. There was a stack of empty pizza boxes on the stovetop, machine parts and a soldering gun on the countertop, and greasy black handprints all over the stainless-steel appliances.

They looked in the living room and saw even more machine parts on the coffee table as well as a stack of programming textbooks against the wall next to the LCD TV.

Steve and Ashley looked at each other with shock on their faces. Ashley mouthed silently, "*Oh, my God!"*

T.J. walked over to the balcony sliding door and opened it, followed by the screen, then he turned down his music slightly. He sat at his computer desk afterwards. Ashley stood at the side of T.J.'s black leather sofa which was now ruined by machine oil.

Steve walked over to T.J. and said, "Teej, *what the fuck?!* You runnin' an auto shop in here or what?"

T.J. ignored him as he stared obsessively into his computer monitor at a website.

"What are you lookin' at?" Steve asked.

"Research on AI and robotics," T.J. replied without looking away from the screen. "You know, back in 2009 the Swedes did an experiment where these robots that looked like toasters had to learn the difference between food and poison without assistance."

"I see…"

"Well," T.J. continued, "some of them figured it out and taught the new generations of robots to tell the difference too."

T.J. looked at Steve with a stoned, paranoid glare. "But eventually the *newer* generations started lying to the *newest* generations, and got *them* to take the poison so they could keep the food for themselves. They learned how to kill."

"That's very interesting, Teej," Steve said.

T.J. grabbed his bong and brewed up a toke.

Steve gestured around the apartment to the enormous mess. "But what the hell is all this?" he demanded.

"*Know your enemy as you know yourself…*" T.J. replied before inhaling the smoke.

"What?" Steve said.

T.J. exhaled a cloud of grey smoke.

"What?" he replied, "You never read *the Art of War?"*

"Okay Teej," Steve said sarcastically, "fine, you're goin' to war… Now let me have a toke."

Steve grabbed the bong from T.J. and walked away with it.

T.J. looked at Ashley who immediately looked down at the ruined couch.

"Well," T.J. said, "have a seat, since you're here."

"I'm fine, really," Ashley replied.

T.J. shrugged. "Fine, don't." His smart phone beeped as he received a text message. He glanced at his phone in excitement.

"Sweet!" he shouted. He jumped out of his chair and hopped over to the balcony. He stepped outside as Ashley walked over to the computer desk and sat down in the chair.

Steve put the bong down on the cluttered coffee table and turned to look at T.J. A white quad copter drone descended from the sky carrying a *FedEx* box beneath it. The drone touched down on the floor of the balcony and released the package then ascended to the sky again.

T.J. grabbed the package and stepped back inside. He turned to the computer desk and stopped abruptly as he noticed Ashley sitting in his spot. Ashley smiled sheepishly, and in return T.J. merely grunted and turned towards the couch.

Ashley frowned as her ex-boyfriend shunned her; in all honesty, she did not expect anything less. Still, it saddened and disappointed her that she had been right about him all along -- Thomas Jennings was an incomprehensible asshole. T.J. ripped open the white *FedEx* box and pulled out well over fifty thick metal washers that remained physically stuck together.

One by one he pulled them apart and placed them on the coffee table in two separate piles. As T.J. sorted the piles, Steve noticed that the cylinders that were dropped onto the coffee table appeared to physically distance themselves from any nearby metal washers, either by sliding away or by standing up on end and literally rolling away as though of their own accord. Ashley looked down at T.J. with a perplexed expression on her face.

Steve looked at him as well. "What the hell is that?" he asked.

"Magnets," T.J. replied bluntly as he stood up. He then walked into the kitchen and rummaged through the cupboards.

"No shit," Steve retorted. "*Why* do you have a bunch of magnets?"

"'Cause I needed them."

T.J. lifted a large binder from a cupboard and dropped it onto the countertop. He opened the binder and flipped through several pages.

Ashley and Steve exchanged glances as T.J. brought a soldering gun and a tool bag over to the coffee table. He placed them all on the table and went back to the kitchen to grab more stuff.

"Teej," Steve said, "you think you can sit still for a few minutes? We came here to talk to you."

Without looking in Steve's direction T.J. simply replied, "About what?"

T.J. brought a cookie sheet filled with metal parts, plates and wires into the living room. He sat down and pulled a handful of thin metal rods out of the tool bag then pulled a bag of screws out as well. Steve stood across the table from T.J. and glared at him.

"*Hey!*" Steve demanded. "You listenin'?!"

"Yeah, I'm listenin', I'm sittin'!" T.J. exclaimed. "What do you *want*?"

T.J. opened the bag and dumped the screws onto the cookie sheet. He then placed the rods into a trio of holes on its edges.

"Did you see Bill Maher last night?" Steve asked.

"I haven't watched him in months."

T.J. used a screwdriver to fasten the ends of the rods in place on the circular plate.

"Well," Steve continued, "he was talkin' about two-legged robots with guns in the army and the LAPD."

"So?"

T.J. inserted the rods into holes in one of the fifty magnetic washers and slid the base of the rod to the bottom of the plate. He repeated this process with more of the magnets.

"*So*," Steve choked, "I wanted to check on you and see how you're doin'."

Finally, T.J. looked up from his little project and glared at Steve with an unimpressed expression of contempt.

"I'm fine, Steve," T.J. said slowly and deliberately. "So, *why* are you *really* here?"

T.J. then looked back down at his array of magnets. There was a cold, tense silence as Steve paused to think over what T.J. meant by his question. In the end however, Steve changed the subject.

"What are you building?" Steve asked.

"A magnetic gauss rifle."

Steve scoffed in disbelief. "A *gauss rifle?!*"

"Yeah."

"... Why?"

"Why not?" T.J. replied. "Robots are bulletproof, right? So it makes sense to be able to shoot magnetized bullets at them."

Steve slapped his own head in disbelief. "Jesus, T.J.," Steve showed all signs of disgust within his voice as he spoke to his old friend with heavy prejudice. "You've spent *almost a year* building *a fucking gun?!*"

T.J. shrugged. "No," he said, "not just a gun..."

Steve's facial expression betrayed his fearful concern. "Oh God, Teej," he said, "what *else* have you built?"

"Meh," T.J. muttered with indifference, "a few different things."

"... What kinds of *things*?"

"Check under my bed and in my dresser -- middle drawer under my shirts. Don't touch anything."

Steve glared at T.J. as he walked out of the living room towards T.J.'s bedroom. Meanwhile, T.J. continued placing the magnetic washers in place as Ashley watched him. She turned down T.J.'s speakers even further as she tried to find something to say to him.

T.J. chuckled to himself, then broke into mild, quiet laughter. He muttered to himself, "He's gonna shit his pants."

"What?" Ashley said.

"Nothin'," T.J. replied.



Ashley placed her arms on her legs as she began to feel awkward and unwelcome.

"So," she said reluctantly, "how have you been?"

T.J. grunted.

"... You've been sleeping fine?" Ashley asked.

"Sure," T.J. said. "Why wouldn't I?"

Ashley looked down at the floor. "I don't know…" she said quietly.

T.J. eyed her briefly then continued placing his magnets together.

"*What the fuck is all this?!*" Steve bellowed from within the bedroom.

T.J. snickered as Steve came storming back into the living room with a metal cylinder in his hand. Ashley saw the cylinder and her eyes widened with intense fear.

"T.J.!" Steve shouted angrily. He shoved the metal cylinder in T.J.'s face. "What the fuck *is this?* You're making pipe bombs now?"

T.J. grabbed the cylinder out of his hand and placed it beside him.

"Watch how you handle that, man!" T.J. exclaimed. "You could set it off treatin' it like that."

"T.J.," Ashley shrieked, "are you out of your mind?! Why are you making *bombs?!"*

"What?" T.J. looked at Ashley. He grabbed the cylinder which made Ashley flinch.

"It's not a bomb," T.J. continued, "it's an EMP grenade."

"*EMP?*" Ashley repeated.

"Yeah," T.J. chuckled. "Only way this' gonna kill you is if you have a pacemaker."

T.J. placed the metal cylinder back on the couch.

"Why do you have that?" Ashley demanded.

"Yeah," Steve interjected, "and why is your *dresser* filled with them - are you goin' fuckin' nuts?!"

"And why do you have a *gun*?!" Ashley continued.

T.J. gave the two of them alternating glances.

"What're you two," T.J. asked, "cops?"

"This is ridiculous!" Steve walked out of the living room and headed into the bathroom.

Ashley looked at T.J. with concern.

"T.J.," she said softly, "we're here because we're worried about you… *I'm* worried about you."

T.J. grunted and went back to building his homemade gun.

"T.J.," Ashley pleaded, "look at me, don't just sluff me off!"

T.J. ignored her.

Impatient, Ashley stood up and stepped over to the couch. She sat down beside her ex-boyfriend whom she still had feelings for and grabbed one of his hands. With her free hand she turned his head to face her.

"T.J.," she said firmly, "look at me."

Reluctantly, T.J. gazed into her bright blue eyes, shimmering with a mixture of strong emotions. T.J.'s eyes were tired and darkened, as though his mind intentionally blocked certain torturous images from ever reaching the back of his eyes. Still, Ashley recognized something in them.

Just being this close to T.J. brought a rush of old emotions back to Ashley's heart. Her inner thighs began to warm and tingle. *My God,* she thought to herself, *it's been so long.*

At the moment T.J. felt nothing and expressed just as much. He still loved Ashley and he knew that she still loved him -- she would never have come to his home if she didn't. Still, she left him and for that reason alone he resented her.

He tried to look away but she held his head in its place.

"Please, T.J.," Ashley begged, "talk to me. What's going on?"

T.J. scoffed and smirked. "You didn't listen before…" he said.

"I know," Ashley responded with a defeated tone to her voice. "And I'm sorry I didn't believe you. It just didn't make any sense. But you were right, I know that now - and I want to help you."

"Hmm…" T.J. knew she was being sincere but still he resisted. *Just because she feels this way* now *doesn't mean she always will*, he thought to himself.

"You want to help me?" he asked, to which Ashley nodded yes. Without blinking or betraying what thoughts lingered beyond his blackened corneas, T.J. said sharply, "Let me finish what I am doing."

His stare was hard and cold. Ashley's eyes were glossy with tears forming. *He's gone*, she thought to herself.

She put her hands down and looked away while T.J. continued working on his gun. Ashley stood up and walked out onto the balcony. T.J. watched her as she left the living room. He wanted to go to her - he knew she was hurt - but he kept working away.

Steve left the bathroom and walked into the kitchen and opened the fridge. There was nothing to eat. Several half-empty soda bottles populated the shelves and nothing else.

"Don't tell me," Steve said to T.J., "you blew *all* your money on that shit you're making?!"

"None of your business, actually," T.J. replied. "But no I didn't - I'm not stupid."

Steve turned around and looked around the living room.

"Where's Ash?" Steve demanded.

T.J. gestured his head toward the balcony as he put the last magnetic washer in place. He started soldering a metal plate over the end of his makeshift barrel.

Steve walked out of the kitchen and around the coffee table. He crouched down across from T.J. in front of the LCD TV.

"Teej," Steve said to T.J., "what the fuck, man? Go talk to her, at least."

"About what?" T.J. said absently.

"She's worried about you, man. She still cares about you."

"Good for her."

"T.J.," Steve repeated in a firmer tone before lowering his voice just above a whisper. "She's fuckin' *homeless*, man! She's been crashin' on our couch since you two split."

Steve continued ranting to T.J., "She hasn't even *talked* to another guy in over *a damn year!* She's not over you, man… Just go talk to her."

T.J. put down the soldering gun. "There, the barrel's almost done," he mused to himself. "I just need a welding torch and I can finish the rest!"

T.J. sat back and placed his arms over the top of the couch. For once during Steve's visit to T.J.'s realm of chaos, T.J. looked content and relaxed.

Steve exhaled. "Fuck it!" he shouted. "She misses you and wants you back and don't give a shit! Have fun makin' your little toys, *alone*."

Steve stood up and walked over to the balcony. Ashley turned around hoping it was T.J.

"Come on Ash," Steve said, "let's go back."

Ashley opened her mouth to protest, but knew it was no use. Reluctantly, she stepped inside from the balcony, she followed Steve as they walked around the couch. Steve stormed towards the door as Ashley swiftly stopped adjacent to T.J. and ran the palm of her hand on his shoulder and up to his face.

T.J. continued looking down at his unfinished gun as if Ashley didn't exist. He could no longer tell for sure whether or not he wanted her to leave or stay.

"My number's still the same," Ashley said, "if you ever feel like talking."

She took her hand away and walked out the door with Steve.

Steve and Ashley descended the stairs to the front stoop of the three-storey brownstone together. Shortly after the music started blaring its trip-hop cacophony again. At the same time they heard a series of clicks as T.J. relocked his door.

"Fucking slob!" Steve seethed, visibly frustrated with his old friend.

Ashley's eyes were hard as stone as she descended the stairs. However, when they exited the brownstone her eyes softened. She tried to hide her tearful sobs as they walked down the busy street to no avail.

Unbeknownst to the two of them, T.J. walked Steve and Ashley from the balcony as they disappeared around the corner. He wished they never came over as he no longer had time for their criticisms or ignorances. Still, he wished Ashley would reappear around the corner and come back to him, because he could never stand to see her hurting.

He walked back into the living room and sat down at the computer desk. He was too proud to call her and tell her to come back. To keep himself distracted he looked online for stories about these army robots Steve had previously told him about.

00011

July 1

Year 3 T.S.

"Lieutenant, it's time."

Lieutenant Marcus Staacman was nudged awake by his second-in-command, Master-Sergeant Martin. His heart jumped but only for an instant as he familiarized himself with the soft dirt and dim moonlight of his manmade foxhole. He opened his eyes and saw the silhouette of his subordinate NCO crouching above him. Staacman pulled himself up and Martin stepped back a couple of paces.

Martin briefed Staacman: "Captain Jonas wants us ready in five mikes sir."

"I want to be up in two," Staacman replied.

Martin left Staacman and approached the other soldiers who all slept in their own individual foxholes. Meanwhile Staacman pulled on his combat jacket and zipped up his vest. He didn't bother to check the time for he already knew it was almost *zero-dark* hours and he knew this meant he had about two hours of sleep.

He climbed out of the shallow hole he had dug himself and mulled over in his head the objections he earlier aired to Major Henson, his unit Commander. Staacman still believed the plan was stupid and very dangerous. After his own past experiences he just couldn't see how the Major could possibly trust these Gabriel models on the front lines.

The Major took his objections with a grain of salt. Instead Major Henson told Lieutenant Staacman, "First of all, these models are *not* under private military control. They were *never* rogue machines like the ones Special Operations Command created your *venerous Cybernetic Countermeasures* Unit to deal with.

"And Second, son," Henson rambled on, "there were *no* reported incidents of rogue Adam models since the failed Search & Rescue op at the *HAARP* complex*."*

"Third - and this strictly between you and me, Lieutenant - the local military forces in the Middle East were essentially *useless* in the coalition force's war on the terror organizations. Fourth, the Commander-in-Chief is *still* trying to keep the *appearance* of upholding the past administration's promise that no combat troops were to be deployed overseas. That agreement is to remain for as long as their memory, or our lives last - whichever comes first."

In the end, the use of *Gabriel* models on the ground in the Middle East was strictly to remain a *political* decision. But word among the officers was that the top Brass were considering using the Gabriels in *Operation: COLD RESPONSE* in the Arctic circle if they proved to be successful here.

The Major was right about one thing: Staacman could not complain about his unit's posting. Up until two weeks ago his entire unit had been dismissed from duty indefinitely after the Army's Intelligence and Security Command decided the *HAARP* incident was no longer an immediate threat. Staacman knew that only meant they were giving up on the situation.

They could find no military strategy suitable for retaking the complex. They didn't know how many Adam models were still inside the compound, the climate in Alaska was gradually getting worse and becoming nearly unlivable. And nobody wanted to risk the potential hundreds of thousands of civilian lives that would be lost if the enemy used *HAARP to its* full potential.

So far their 'do-nothing' tactic was not costing them lives. The climate over the state of Alaska had levelled out and became similar to the Arctic Circle and nobody noticed any more hostile activity beyond the foot of Mt. McKinley. As a result, the Joint Chiefs determined that *CYCO* Unit's mission was complete.

All members of the above-top-secret unit were put on standby for five months pending reassignment throughout the ranks of the Army's Special Operations Command. They were now, for all intents and purposes, a specialist attachment to the Military Police. Their newest assignment, as of two weeks ago, was to police the Gabriel models on the front lines and be prepared to react if something bad happened.

However, their unit's job was a thankless one because no US Marine believed anything bad would happen, or at the very least, they never said it out loud. For the most part, everybody looked at the men of *CYCO* Unit as a bunch of technophobes who had no confidence in the Brass' decisions. Especially since Staacman always had his twelve-man unit armed to the teeth when escorting the Gabriels.

Sergeant Martin had the unit huddled together in a quiet group in the middle of their nomadic camp, as Staacman approached them. Half of the men were still trying to wake themselves up. In particular, the unit's two specialists, Carl Semple and Jefferson Smith, found it the hardest to acclimate to the new time zone and arid climate.

The *CYCO Unit*'s task force members, all former Delta Force operatives, wore night vision goggles attached to their helmets and carried with them their Colt M4A1 Carbine rifles. Their ammunition magazines were filled to capacity with explosive-jacketed rounds.

Semple and Smith wore their thermal goggles high up on their foreheads with bandoliers strapped to their chests. The bandoliers held almost a dozen special Electromagnetic Pulse grenades.

The specialists also carried spray guns that were attached to pressurized liquid-nitrogen canisters on their backs. Staacman stood in front of the small semicircle of men and briefed his team:

"Alright men," Staacman said, "First Recon Battalion got eyes on a stronghold suspected of housing members of Al-Baghdadi's cabinet. The Ops CO got the orders directly from *Scarface*. Recon's gonna send in the Gabriels to waste them all."

"They don't want prisoners, Lieutenant?" Corporal Wilson asked.

Staacman shook his head. "They want to send a message to ISIS and they want to put the raid on video and show the whole world. This is strictly about shock-and-awe."

"So what's our mission sir?"

"We stand fast, escort the Gabriels and secure 'em when the mission's complete."

"So that's it," Wilson said, "we're just supposed to babysit what we used to *hunt*?"

Staacman looked at the Corporal and replied, "Babysitters protect *their charges* from other people, Corporal, *not* the other way around."

"Yes sir."

"This is show time for these robots, gentlemen," Staacman continued. "It's their very first real-world objective. Be ready for anything that might happen.

"But remember: Everybody's expecting them to succeed. Put your prejudices aside until *they* give *us* a reason to take them down."

Staacman looked at Sergeant Martin. "Sergeant," he said, "*Parasite* will be in the lead Humvee. *Virus* and *Telescope* will cover our six. Keep your eyes open for hostiles on the horizon.

"Yes sir," Martin replied.

"Our patches may say *CYCO* but we're still Special Forces. Until we get to the site, aim your rifles *downrange*. Let's load up!"

The men all scrambled to the convoy of vehicles in the centre of the camp. Staacman, Carl Semple and one of *CYCO*'s newest members, Adrian Kazansky, loaded up into the rear Humvee that was designated for *Virus* squad. Corporal Wilson, Sergeant Martin and Jefferson Smith loaded up into the front Humvee that was designated for the *Parasite* squad while the six-man squad *Telescope* loaded up into a large cargo truck.

As the two Humvees and cargo truck turned over their engines the two Armoured Personnel Carriers they would be escorting were idling and waiting for *Parasite'*s Humvee to switch into Drive.

The vehicles all switched into gear and got underway into the night. The drivers all wore night vision goggles as they drove. They kept their headlights off as they travelled across hostile territory.

Sergeant Martin rode shotgun in the front Humvee. He aimed his assault rifle out the window while Corporal Wilson manned the rooftop-mounted .50-calibre gun on the rooftop. Jefferson Smith looked at his two squad mates who intently kept a vigilant watch over the surrounding area with their night vision goggles on. He was glad they were both back and recovered from their gunshot wounds they received in Alaska.

For a while both men were on medical leave as they went through physiotherapy. Martin had trouble walking for a while and required reconstructive surgery on the muscles in his leg. One of Wilson's lungs had collapsed and needed a transplant. He was fortunate

enough to find one almost immediately after the incident in Washington DC.

Martin still felt a slight pain in his leg so he received a pair of *T-Rex* braces to help support the weight of his gear. Some of the men from *CYCO* teased him by calling him 'the Bionic man.' The ribbing stopped once Lieutenant Staacman ordered a pair of the leg braces for all of the men under his command. So far, only the specialists wore them regularly to support the weight of their own gear.

Staacman was especially glad to have them back as well. Other than himself, Jefferson and Semple, there were no other surviving members of the original *CYCO* Unit left. *Telescope* was full of battle-hardened Delta Force troops but none of them looked at the Gabriels with the same fear and respect Staacman did. Instead, the new guys looked at them as neat toys that they wanted to fight alongside.

None of them had ever encountered one in combat or even heard about *CYCO* Unit's past missions until after they were assigned to the unit. They heard stories about the Vault in Nevada and about Corporal Guzman's brain injuries, but they never *saw* a machine stalking towards them, preparing to use an oxygen plasma torch as a hunting knife. The stories were just too unreal to them.

After forty-five minutes of driving across the barren desert the vehicles all came to a halt. The stronghold was about a mile away; from here, the Gabriels would travel across the desert on foot. The *CYCO* Unit would slowly advance behind them and prepare to secure the Gabriels once the stronghold was clear.

The twelve men exited the vehicles as the rear hatches on the two APC's slowly lowered to the ground. The men created a half-circle around the opening of the transports as the harnesses which secured the machines were loosened. The four-foot tall combinations of camouflaged steel, ceramic and heavy firepower stepped out one-by-one out of the APCs.

A US Marine stepped out of one of the APC's behind the machines. His face was riddled with deep scars from shrapnel and knife wounds. He wore a black beret with the marine insignia and

although he bore no rank on his fatigues, the men knew he was Captain Jonas, the operational Commanding Officer.

Twelve Gabriel models in total now stood upright in tight ranks facing the Captain. Lieutenant Staacman looked at the Captain, noticing the scars on his face through his night vision goggles. He found it ironic that this man's radio handle was not *Scarface*.

"About *face*," the Captain said in a normal tone of voice. The twelve Gabriel models turned their torsos around and their legs subsequently followed as they snapped to attention, facing *CYCO Unit.*

The Captain continued, "These men are your escorts. Scan and recognize their faces."

The twelve machines slowly turned their heads and glanced at each man for a fraction of a second.

"When the mission is complete," Captain Jonas continued, "you will be under their command until you board the transport. How do you copy?"

Staacman and the others heard a computer-generated voice in their headsets reply, *"Full copy."*

"Commence *Operation NEXUS*."

As soon as the Captain completed his order the twelve camouflaged machines dropped to their hands and feet and sprinted off between the soldiers that surrounded them. They ran to the east and spread out while the men from *CYCO Unit* jogged slowly behind them.

The machines completely surrounded the compound within five minutes but kept a distance of a quarter-mile from the walls of the compound. Still on all fours, they slowly stalked forward. They closed in on the compound walls like a well-organized pack of wolves.



They used their satellite connection with Cerberus half a world away to communicate with each other in dead silence and share their visual findings of the compound's perimeter wall. Their Forward-Looking-Infrared sensors helped them identify hostels on the wall while their Infrared range-finding lasers gave them accurate locations of the enemies. The combined data was collected by Cerberus and used to generate an overhead map image that each model used to plot their movements.

As the perimeter guards made their patrols on the high walls of the armed compound the machines stalked forward like cheetahs inching closer to unsuspecting gazelles. When the guards looked over the walls the Gabriel models stopped and lay prone. Shrouded in darkness and masked by endless sand dunes the sentry patrols never once saw them coming.

By now Cerberus confirmed there were eight guards on the perimeter walls. On each of the four sides of the stronghold a Gabriel model stood tall and extended both arms upward, with each arm aiming .50-calibre gun barrels at their respective guards. The rest of the Gabriel models crawled forward, keeping track of the guards' positions and feeding ballistic vector data to the models that acquired their targets at the back.

The remaining eight Gabriel models came within a hundred feet of the walls and lay on the ground as they dug their diamond-tipped, steel-clawed hind feet into the sand. Preparing like track runners, the models prepared themselves for the big push towards their final goal. Each machine kept their two-and-a-half pairs of electronic eyes fixated on their prey as the guards made their ill-fated final pass in their patrols. The four machines that stood at the rear, leading the position of their targets with their rifle mounts, all opened fire simultaneously.

For miles all that was heard was a single loud, harmonized, deafening ***boom,*** as all eight guards' torsos rained blood and entrails into the compound below.

The two machines next to the compound gate ran to the side ditches next to the makeshift road as the remaining six Gabriels darted toward the walls and pounced upward an inhuman twenty-five

feet to reach the top of the walls. They each gripped the tops of the walls and hoisted themselves up before catching the ledges with their hind legs and briefly sitting on the walls similar to house cats that successfully scale fences. Throughout the compound the men shouted in Arabic as the inhabitants tried to determine the source of the explosion.

Lights switched on in the windows of hardened clay buildings as the residences began to awaken. The six machines split into pairs and took to different rows of maze-like roadways. Robed men burst out of doorways screaming in rage as they aimed their Kalashnikov rifles at the *infidels* and opened fire.

The bullets cracked the ceramic plates and ricocheted off the steel exoskeleton frames. The Gabriels were unmoved as they pointed their accusing arms at their would-be killers and riddled their bodies with giant holes, sometimes cutting through several victims with a single bullet. All the while, women and children screamed in terror as they huddled inside their homes.

The Gabriel models stepped inside the homes; the women, clothed in their black robes and veils, stared in wide-eyed horror as the computer-generated voices said in bland Arabic, *"Keep your children inside, we are not here to hurt you."*

In one of the homes a frightened woman grabbed her slain husband's AK74 and opened fire on a Gabriel model, breaking apart its protective face mask. Her children stared in shock at the featureless, spider-like face of the Gabriel model as though they had just laid eyes on Lucifer himself. In shock, they repeatedly begged Allah for help as the soulless machine shot their panicked mother to death in front of them.

Meanwhile out in the courtyard a handful of militants took cover in a building as a pair of Gabriels lay down suppressing fire. One fighter stood up and faced out the window with an RPG-7 over his shoulder and fired. The rocket found its target centre-mass of a Gabriel model's chest plate. The machine was shredded apart by the pressurized fragments of the exploded rocket.

The other machine kept firing, completely unaffected by the rocket's shockwave. The Gabriel model used its array of sensors to map the exact location of each man in the small building as another

pair of Gabriel models proceeded to flank both sides of the building from the outside. Using the map data they received from Cerberus they shot through the clay walls at the sides of the building, successfully cutting each man down as though they could see through the walls themselves.

Gunfire erupted from the second floor of the main building in the centre of the compound. The Gabriels on the perimeter walls opened fire while dodging incoming rockets. The remaining five Gabriels inside the compound converged on the centremost building.

They watched through the open windows in the walls for movement as streaks of fire and smoke hovered above. A few of the machines climbed the walls and scaled their way to the rooftop while one pair broke open a door to clear the main floor.

The main floor was deserted. A makeshift barricade was erected at the foot of the stairs leading to the second floor. The pair of machines waited on the main floor while the trio above climbed through the windows in a temporary break of gunfire as the militants reloaded their rifles.

The machines entered a second floor bedroom and walked slowly to the door leading to the hallway where more gunshots could be heard. They knew the precise locations of the targets in the next room thanks to the Gabriel models on the outside perimeter walls relaying their exact GPS-delta coordinates, but the incursive machines left them alone. Instead, they snuck past the preoccupied fighters and slowly walked further down the hall.

They cleared three bedrooms one-by-one until they reached the master bedroom. A shirtless, bearded man held up a Kalashnikov rifle and aimed it at the Gabriel model in front of the door, but the machine could not safely open fire as the man was surrounded by several women and children. He was using his own family as human shields.

The man shouted in Arabic for his subordinates to come assist him. The two Gabriels in the hallway turned around and aimed their guns/arms down the hall just as a pair of gunmen burst through the doorway. The men aimed their rifles at the Gabriels just as a barrage of bullets burst through the exterior walls from the models that provided overwatch from outside, cutting them down and killing them.

The man in the room - with almost a dozen human shields - shouted at the intruder to get back and walk away before he started killing hostages. The Gabriel model stood its ground. Using its multiple sensors and cameras to pinpoint the gunman's exact position within the room it relayed the data to the Gabriels in the hallway using a UHF signal.

The Gabriels in the hallway then relayed the same message to a Gabriel model on the compound wall which then sent the information directly to Cerberus. Cerberus then transmitted this data to the rest of the Gabriels outside, and a model on one of the walls aimed its pair of .50-calibre gun barrels at the building. Its line-of-fire was calculated to create a bullet path right through the gunman's head.

The gunman continued to shout maniacally at the four-foot-tall machine that stared him down while generating ear-piercing digital tones. The man consistently thrust his AK74 in front of him, threatening to shoot the children.

Suddenly, the man's head exploded into a red mist and bone fragments. The women and children shrieked in terror and huddled around the dead man as the machine left the room. It headed back to the window to await further commands from Cerberus.

A quarter-mile away, Lieutenant Staacman and his team slowly walked across the barren desert, carefully scanning their surroundings for hostiles or mines as they closed in on the compound.

Staacman's headset crackled to life and a computer-generated voice said, *"All clear; civilians on-site; one friendly casualty; awaiting instructions."*

Staacman then heard Captain Jonas reply over the radio transmission, *"Defend and hold position. Standby."*

"Wilco. Out."

*"*Papa Tree Delta*, did you copy last transmission?"*

"Full copy," Staacman replied. "Oscar Mike. Out."

Staacman looked around at his team and said, "Alright men, let's move, double-time. *Telescope*, you got point."

The twelve men of *CYCO* Unit jogged across the desert to the compound. When the compound finally came into view of their night vision goggles, Staacman called up Captain Jonas on his headset.

"*Cerebrate*, this is *Papa Tree Delta*; be advised, we are approaching A.O. due west. Relay transmission, over."

Staacman knew he was authorized to give commands to Cerberus directly but he didn't trust it at all. He outright refused to even speak to it.

Staacman heard the Captain's voice over his headset. "Overlord*, this is* Cerebrate*; you have friendly troops due west of your twenty, designation:* Papa Tree Delta. *Check fire,over."*

Staacman then heard the computer-generated voice on the radio:

*"*Papa Tree Delta *acquired. The front gate is secure. Break;* Papa Tree Delta *this is* Overlord; *front gate is around the corner to your 3 o'clock. Two friendlies have secured the road ahead. Check fire, over."*

The men approached the compound with caution. They watched the Gabriel models above, perched on the perimeter walls with mistrust. They took cover against the walls as they approached the front gate.

They saw a pair of Gabriels taking cover in the ditches that flanked the road. The front gate creaked and moaned loudly as a Gabriel model pushed it open from within. The men stepped inside the compound and saw women in black burkas huddling around crying children in the middle of the courtyard.

One of the Gabriel models walked up to Staacman and gave him a swift salute. Staacman tensed up as he gripped his M4A1 rifle tighter, caressing the safety mechanism with his thumb and forefinger.

A computer-generated voice emanated from within the chassis of the machine:

"Twenty-one enemy casualties confirmed; primary targets neutralized; one non-combatant killed; one friendly destroyed."

Staacman's heart jumped from fear. "How did the civilian die?" he demanded.

"A woman grabbed an AK47 assault rifle and opened fire. The woman posed a risk to the mission and a potential risk to other civilian children around her."

"She probably thought the same about you," Staacman muttered dismissively.

He then turned and spoke into his headset, "*Telescope*, secure the wall. *Parasite*, guard the women and children. *Overlord*, regroup on me and stand down. *Cerebrate*, NEXUS is successful and AO is secure. Send in the transports ASAP, over."

Captain Jonas sent the convoy on its way to rendezvous at the compound as *Telescope* scrambled up to the walls and the Gabriels all lined up ranks of three in the courtyard, standing at attention per Staacman's command, waiting for the APC to arrive. Staacman hoped one of them would flinch so they could scrap them all.

He didn't believe for a second that the dead woman posed any *real* threat - she was probably frightened for her children's lives. *Any* human *would have known that*, he thought to himself.

He resolved to make sure Major Henson knew about this and that Major-General Antoine Wilkes received Staacman's recommendation that Cerberus be decommissioned from independent combat missions. He wasn't sure if General Wilkes would listen, but after the HAARP incident he felt he had the General's ear, at the very least.

He kept his eyes intently on the unmoving machines and caressed the trigger on his rifle as he impatiently waited for the convoy to arrive. He tried to work out in his mind what excuse there could possibly be for killing a woman in front of her children. He never wanted to shoot *something* so badly.

00100

July 2
Year 3 T.S.

The digital alarm clock on the nightstand buzzed repeatedly with its annoying monotone. To T.J., it was a heart-compressing shrill reminder to his unconscious mind that it was time to wake up and get ready for another day at the office. Half-asleep, T.J. bolted upright in his bed, twisted his body to face the clock and smashed his open palm on the top button of the clock.

The alarm went silent and T.J. sat still and stared at the unmoving clock face. 7:15am. T.J. selfishly reminisced on what he considered to be his 'golden period,' the only good thing that came out of the pandemic almost 5 years ago: never worrying about sleeping in, or catching the train uptown - when he worked from home. When the whole world had to.

The black curtains over his window kept the morning sun out of his room, tricking his body into believing the rest of the world was still sleeping. He got out of bed and walked over to his door. As soon as he opened it his eyes began to adjust to the bright orange glow of the morning sun that saturated his hallway. He turned to the bathroom door on his right and went inside, closing the door behind him.

T.J. stood in front of the toilet and relieved his bladder. Absent-mindedly, he began to pay attention to the distinct noises of New York City that permeated through the open window behind the half-drawn shower curtain. Flushing the toilet, T.J. removed his boxers, stepped into the bathtub then ran the shower.

After cleaning the night sweat from his body T.J. towelled off and went back into the bedroom. He put on a pair of jeans, a t-shirt and a hoodie, then went back to the bathroom to brush his teeth. When all was said and done, T.J. grabbed his backpack from the bedroom, walked into the living room and loaded his laptop into the backpack.

He put on a pair of running shoes and left his apartment. Locking his door, T.J. descended the several flights of stairs and walked down the front stoop. He walked down the street to the train station.

He caught the train to Manhattan and stared out the window at the cityscape as it scrolled by. As if it were a sobre reminder from God himself, T.J. listened quietly to the soft-spoken, fearful wails of Sam Cooke playing on his smart phone through his ear buds as T.J.'s peripheral vision caught a glance of the freshly-dug mass graves on Hart Island…

"It's been a long...
Long time coming
But I know
a change is gonna come...
Oh, yes it will!"

As he exited the train and left the station T.J. walked down the street. The song *Happy* by Pharrell Williams started to play in his ear buds. The song reminded him of that night almost three years ago, when he took Ashley to that comedy club *Three Smile Island*, and then she stayed with him at his place for the whole weekend for the very first time…

His eyes widened and T.J. immediately halted his entire train of thought. He looked skyward, between the tall skyscrapers of Manhattan Island to the sparse clouds above as he tried painfully in his heart to force down the love-filled smile that had commandeered his face. He thought to himself, *God, it would be* so easy *to get it all back… God I want her back…*

His eyes shut involuntarily as though to punish him for desiring such naive delusions. A quiet yet clear voice pushed his thought process forward. He told himself, ...*But if I did, it just wouldn't be the same.*

He pressed the chrome button on his headset to change the song. Instantaneously, the nasally voice of Louis Mario 'B Real' Freese asked his cacophony of drunken and stoned Cypress Hill fans without any hint of discomfort, *"Do you wanna get high?! Does everybody wanna get HIGHHH!!"*

T.J. looked straight ahead and kept walking, and smiling to himself for a different reason now as he pulled a small spliff from a

hollowed-out laser pointer and lit it as he rounded the corner and approached the front steps leading to the main lobby of *Chaotic Entertainment*.

T.J. walked inside when his spliff had shrunk to the size of a small roach. In the foyer stood a ten-foot-tall cardboard cutout of a menacing, red-eyed dark hooded figure wearing combat fatigues, carrying a bloody knife and a pistol. Its lower legs were covered in blood stains and its jacked was covered in burn marks.

At the bottom of the cutout, in bold gold-coloured embossed letters, was the title of their latest game to be released - *Red Star*. T.J. liked the original working title, *Revenge* better. He walked past the giant shape-shifting unnamed alien to the main offices where many of his coworkers were just settling in for another eight hours of staring into computer screens until their eyes began to bleed tears inexplicably. Half of the staff typed away vicariously, ignoring the numb pain that began to envelop their brains, hands, wrists, triceps and shoulder blades.

T.J. walked through the hall of cubicles, glancing briefly at each coworker who all seemed to ignore him for their own work. T.J. reached his own cubicle and unpacked his laptop. He sat down at his desk and switched on his computer. He typed in his username and password then opened the editor environment for the game.

T.J. checked the latest updates from the AI department and double-checked everybody's work to ensure the lines of code would not create conflicts later on. He then checked his free-running engine to see if anybody had tried to make changes to it and found none. *Good*, T.J. thought to himself.

T.J. checked the company log to see the list of bugs and glitches that had been reported by their player base. He found several bugs with his freerunning engine and proceeded to go through his thousands of lines of code to fix the problems.

For the next three hours T.J. made tweaks to various objects in his engine. After a few tweaks he ran the game in developer mode to test his tweaks then went back to making more tweaks. He didn't even look at the time until he sensed people walking past him to go for lunch. He put both his computer and laptop in sleep mode and left the building to go to a McDonald's down the road.

The streets of Manhattan were flooded with the afternoon rush of businessmen and women. He navigated the sea of black suits until he saw the giant golden arches and walked through them to the smell of grease, salt and fried potatoes. The restaurant was almost as packed as the streets behind T.J. but still he chose to wait in line.

He periodically glanced up at the flat screen TVs around the restaurant that displayed different channels. Some showed various news networks while others showed highlights from last week's football games.

When he reached the cashier T.J. ordered a Big Mac with a medium serving of fries and a large drink. He was perplexed by people who ordered smaller-sized drinks. After all, they all cost the same and refills were free.

He sat down at a bar-style table and stool and alternated his gaze between three different TVs in front of him while he ate his lunch. On one screen was a highlight from a previous football game showing a player being physically taunted several times by an opposing player. Eventually the first player had enough and started trying to instigate a fistfight with the other player.

Both teams rushed to the field to stop the two players from beating each other up. The middle screen showed footage from robots that were being called *Gabriels*. The third screen showed a female reporter outside a Los Angeles courthouse talking about the arraignment of several Mexican cartel members that were arrested in a raid four days ago.

T.J. looked away from the TVs and grabbed his smart phone from his pocket. He opened his internet browser and searched the news feeds for more on those machines on TV. An article on CNN's website reported on a press conference that a company named Global Technologies Enterprise was going to have tonight at seven o'clock Eastern Time.

The report made no mention as to the purpose of the press conference but it did mention that organized protests outside of GTE's headquarters in California. It also mentioned a piece of legislation that was in the making on behalf of police unions across the nation, and a recent death at GTE's headquarters. T.J. decided he would watch the conference and dig into other stories later.

T.J. finished his lunch and emptied his tray into the garbage before leaving. The streets were just as busy as before as he navigated through the sea of people on his way back to the main lobby at Chaotic Entertainment.

As he entered the front doors to the main lobby T.J. saw the old man, Alfred T. Mason, embracing his daughter - T.J.'s half-sister Jennifer - as she prepared to leave. The old man smiled as he said goodbye and turned back to the giant oak double-doors of his office. He didn't even notice T.J. as he approached.

Jennifer turned around and saw T.J. She gave him a closed-mouth smile and a small wave of the hand as he approached.

"Hi Tom," Jennifer said.

"Hey Jen," T.J. replied. "What're you doin' here?"

"Oh, I was going to do some shopping so I thought I'd stop by and say hi to dad."

"Ah," T.J. replied, "okay…"

"...So," Jennifer said awkwardly, "how have you been?"

T.J. shrugged. "I've been alright," he replied.

"That's good."

"How's the family?"

"Great!" Jennifer smiled genuinely. "Darren's turning three in a week!"

"Oh, wow!"

"Yeah! I can't believe it! Where has the time gone?"

"Yeah." T.J. paused briefly before saying, "Well, I better get back to work."

"Okay," Jennifer responded. "Well, take care Tom."

"Yeah, you too," T.J. said as he began to walk away.

"Hey Tom," Jennifer called out.

T.J. turned around to face her, anxious to leave.

Jennifer continued, "His birthday's next Wednesday. Darren would love to see you if you wanted to stop by…"

T.J. thought about it briefly. "Yeah," he said, "I might stop by."

Jennifer almost seemed disappointed with T.J. "Well," she said, "I'll see you later." She then turned and left.

T.J. never got along with his three half-siblings on his father's side. Brock and Timothy, the two brothers, blamed T.J. for their

parents' divorce. Jennifer did at first as well but, after a while, she began to warm up to T.J.

Jennifer was a little more sympathetic to T.J.'s situation than the rest of her family. She recognized that it was her father that made the conscious decision to cheat on their mother, Jessica. Still, T.J. was sure she didn't really want him to show up to his nephew's birthday. He figured he might regardless, if only just to piss his older brothers off.

T.J. sat down at his computer and laptop. He brought both devices out of sleep mode and continued debugging the video game that had made him a silent millionaire. 'Silent,' because he never told anybody how much money he had made.

Sure, he told Steve about his two-percent royalty fee. It was also public knowledge how many copies of the new game had been sold to date, but nobody knew for sure *exactly* how much T.J. had left.

The truth was, T.J. had almost *all of it* left; he just had no reason to spend that money. He didn't want a car because he felt New York Transit and parkour was sufficient, and traffic jams made him anxious now. He didn't need a house because he was still a bachelor.

He was comfortable in Brooklyn and thus didn't want to move uptown to a better neighbourhood. His salary covered his entire budget anyway. He didn't know what to do with the money, so he felt it would be best if he just forgot that it existed for now.

By the end of the work day T.J.'s eyes were sore and his hands were tired. He saved his work and logged his changes into the *Chaotic Entertainment Intranet* then packed his laptop into his backpack. He then left for the train station.

T.J. walked along the Manhattan streets and watched his shadow stretch across the road from the late afternoon sun. The music from his ear buds was interrupted by his smart phone's ringtone. He checked the caller ID on his phone and, to his surprise, it was his old neighbour, Legs.

T.J. pressed the chrome button on his headset to answer the call.

"Hey what's up, Legs?" he said.

"Chillin' dog," was the reply over his headset. *"What 'bout you, you good?"*

"Yeah I'm alright. What's up?"

"You got plans this weekend?"

"Uh, not really. Why?"

"There's a release party happenin' this weekend, dog. You should come through."

"Oh yeah, cool."

"Yeah, there's gonna be pure dimes there, dog. I bet it's time you get your dick wet." Legs chuckled.

T.J. chuckled non committedly. "Cool," he replied. "Just text me the details."

"For sure. Peace." Legs hung up.

T.J. walked up the staircase to the train terminal and took the train back to Brooklyn. As he walked down the street at dusk he spontaneously decided to visit his mother. He walked past his street and knocked on the front door of his mother's duplex.

A moment later the door opened and his mother, Theresa Jennings, opened the door. She looked pleasantly surprised to see him.

"Oh," she said, "hi T.J."

"Hey mom," T.J. said.

Theresa stepped back from the door and her large husky, Otis, came running up to T.J. He leaned down to rub the big dog's muzzle.

"Hey bonehead!" T.J. exclaimed. "How you doin'?"

Otis sniffed his face excitedly and tried to lick his face.

"No," T.J. said, "go inside!" He pointed down the hall.

Otis wagged his tail as he trotted down the hall to wait for his owner and her son.

T.J. stepped inside and slipped off his shoes as Theresa closed the front door.

"I wish you told me you were coming," she said. "I didn't plan on making dinner tonight." She walked into the living room.

"Oh well, I'll just order a pizza." T.J. followed her into the living room. "So how's everything?"

Theresa sat at the sofa and lit a cigarette. "Hmm," she said, "can't complain. Beverly and I took a trip to Atlantic City last weekend."

"Oh yeah, how was it?"

"It was good. We won a hundred dollars at the slots."

"Oh yeah, how much did you spend?"

"About a hundred."

T.J. chuckled. "Oh well, at least you broke even."

"Yeah. Beverly wanted to keep playing, but I convinced her to watch a show instead."

"That's probably a good thing."

T.J. grabbed his phone from his pocket and disconnected the headset. He dialled the number for a pizza shop and ordered a large deluxe with two pounds of Buffalo wings and a two-litre bottle of Pepsi.

T.J. hung up the phone and activated a timer on it. "Forty-five minutes or less," he said.

"So," Theresa began, "how have you been?"

T.J. shrugged, "I've been alright," he replied.

"Are you still being a shut-in?"

Theresa grinned. T.J. looked at her in surprise.

"Oh, come on T.J., you think I don't hear things?"

T.J. scoffed and grinned. "Steve, right?"

"Ha, I'm not going to tell…" Theresa pulled a drag from her smoke. "But listen, you need to stop living in the past. Now don't get me wrong, you're a handsome man but…" Theresa pointed at his unkempt beard, "you've let yourself go."

T.J. rolled his eyes as his mother continued. "Now if you want to chase robots in your spare time, be my guest, but you have a good life too. You have a beautiful girl that's still in love with you… don't look at me like that, I'm serious. You have a great career and a lot of money. And I'm *still* waiting for grandkids!"

T.J. chuckled. "You want grandkids anytime soon," he joked, "you might want to have *another* kid first."

Theresa smacked him lightly on the back of the head.

"Don't mess with me, T.J.," she said, "I want to see you get married and have a few kids before I die."

"Well, I don't think you have to worry about that…"

"No, I think I do." Theresa puffed on her smoke. "Ashley is a very nice girl. I may have only met her a few times but I can tell she's one of a kind. Much better than that other girl - what's her name… Candace, or…"

"Jill," T.J. said.

"Right... *Jill*," Theresa repeated with contempt. "There was something wrong with *that one*."

T.J. nodded as his mother continued. "Now you can get any woman you like Tommy, but let's get this straight: they won't be *anything* like that poor woman you keep sloughing off."

T.J. knew his mother only called him *Tommy* whenever she was trying to show him that she was right in no uncertain terms.

"Yeah," he muttered.

"You need to stop taking the break-up so personal. A woman can only feel unwanted for so long before she finally walks away."

"Pfft, I didn't *not* want her."

"Well, I'm sure that's how you came across to her, especially the other day."

T.J. pointed his finger at his mother. "Now that," he said, "was intentional."

"Yeah, of course it was. I didn't expect any less from you."

T.J. raised an eyebrow at her. Theresa shrugged her shoulders, turned her gaze back to the TV and puffed on her cigarette. They watched a rerun of *Modern Family*_as they waited for the pizza delivery.

It arrived thirty-eight minutes later, which disappointed TJ because he wanted a free pizza. He paid the bill and brought the food into the living room. Otis ran into the room, stuffing his muzzle into the plastic bags of wings before being swatted away and told to go lay down.

Otis lowered his head and waved off into the kitchen, his long nails clicking on the tile floor. They opened the pizza box and started pulling apart the large pie as they flipped through channels, continuing their small talk as they ate.

A couple hours later they had eaten all they could and they packed away the remaining food. They split the remaining food in half and hugged briefly as T.J left for home. He walked down the street among the twilight of a June evening.

It was kind of chilly and T.J. only wore a hoodie, but he didn't have far to walk anyway. He reached his stoop in a matter of minutes. He entered his brownstone apartment, checked his mailbox and found nothing then walked up his flight of steps to his apartment.

He unlocked the door and stepped inside. He flipped a light switch and the living room became illuminated from two tall fluorescent lamps in corners of the room. He kicked off his shoes and took the food over to the kitchen counter.

He grabbed a plate from one of his cupboards and filled it with ribs and two slices of pizza. He grabbed a glass mug and filled it with Pepsi then took his plate and mug over to the coffee table.He switched on his TV and tuned in to AMC where a marathon of Summer movies was being showcased.

T.J. stood up and walked over to the computer desk then grabbed a Ziploc bag full of marijuana and brought it back over to the coffee table and opened it. He pulled some buds out and started picking them apart before placing them in the large glass bowl of his bong.

When are they gonna legalize it here in New York? He asked himself. He picked up his lighter and brewed up a toke. He inhaled a thick cloud of smoke and held it in as long as he could before letting it out in a violent coughing fit.

He put down the bong and looked at his table. It was covered in electronics and machine parts. He started rounding up the parts into a single pile, stood up from the couch and took the parts into the kitchen.

He placed them on a cookie sheet that was covered in even more machine parts, and his half-finished gauss rifle. He then walked back over to the couch. He sat down and began to subtly feel the almost-imperceptible changes in his senses as the marijuana started to take its effect on him.

Sitting down in front of his fifty-inch television, watching classic summer movies with pizza and wings he had a sudden epiphany of how awesome his life was. He looked around his awesome apartment and decided it needed to be cleaned - only later.

He looked over at his balcony and thought about all the times he had smoked on it.

He looked down at the busy street and thought to himself just how lucky he was to live here. He looked at his computer and marvelled at how it was wirelessly connected to his Xbox One, his television, his interior lighting…

He could even use his smart phone to change music on his computer! His home seemed so cool to him at that moment and he